

Deployment & Jira Setup — AB Bank Chatbot

Standalone reference · updated 2026-07-22

Two things this bot needs that aren't running yet: a place for the backend to live on the internet, and (optionally) a real connection to the contact center's Jira. Neither one needs IT — both are written up here as a standalone reference so they can be handed to whoever ends up owning each piece (e.g. yourself for Render, the contact-center team for Jira).

Part 1 — Hosting the backend (Render, free, no IT needed)

The chatbot has two halves: the **widget** (the chat button embedded on the WordPress site — see `wordpress-plugin/README.md`) and the **backend** (the Python app that actually understands messages and answers them). The widget is just a script tag; it needs the backend running somewhere reachable on the internet 24/7. Right now the backend only runs on a local computer (`INSTRUCTIONS.md §1`), which stops working the moment that computer is off or offline.

This repo is already set up to deploy for free on **Render** — no server to manage, no IT ticket.

Steps

1. Go to render.com and sign up for a free account, signing in with the GitHub account this project is already pushed to: `choolwec/ab-bank-chatbot-demo`.
2. **New** → **Web Service** → select this repo. Render reads the `render.yaml` file already committed at the root of the repo and fills in every setting itself (Python runtime, free plan, the correct start command) — nothing to type or configure by hand.
3. Click **Create Web Service**. The first deploy takes a few minutes. When it finishes, Render gives a public URL, e.g. `https://ab-bank-chatbot-demo.onrender.com`.
4. Still in the Render dashboard, open the service's **Environment** tab and add the two variables below, then save — Render redeploys automatically.
5. Back in WordPress admin: **Settings** → **AB Bank Chatbot**, paste the Render URL from step 3, **Save**. See `wordpress-plugin/README.md` if the plugin itself isn't installed yet.

Required environment variables on Render

Variable	Value	Why
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ALLOWED_ORIGINS	<code>https://abbank.co.zm</code> (the real WordPress domain, comma-separate if there's more than one, e.g. a staging URL)	Without this, the widget loads but every chat message is silently blocked by the browser (CORS). Defaults to <code>localhost</code> only.
PROXY_HOPS	<code>1</code>	Render puts every app behind its own edge proxy, so without this every visitor's messages would appear to come from Render's proxy IP — collapsing all real users into one shared 20-messages/minute rate limit bucket instead of one bucket each.

Everything else (`JIRA_*` , retention days, etc.) can be added the same way later — see Part 2 and `README.md` 's "Before launch" checklist.

The one catch: Render's free tier puts the service to sleep after ~15 minutes with no visitors; the next message after that takes ~30-50 seconds to wake it back up. That's fine for a low-traffic pilot (under 100 users/month). If that delay becomes a real problem once traffic grows, Render's cheapest paid tier (~\$7/month) removes it — a small, justifiable upgrade once the pilot proves the bot is worth keeping, not a day-one cost.

Part 2 — Connecting real Jira

The bot already pushes every fraud/complaint/callback ticket toward Jira (`app/jira_export.py`) — right now in **mock mode**, writing fake tickets (`CC-1` , `CC-2` , ...) to `data/jira_mock.jsonl` because no real credentials are set. Flipping it to real mode is four environment variables and **no code change**.

Variable	What it is	Where to get it
<code>JIRA_BASE_URL</code>	The Jira site's URL	The address bar when logged into Jira, e.g. <code>https://abbank.atlassian.net</code>
<code>JIRA_EMAIL</code>	Login email for the account the bot will act as	Whoever's account this is — see below
<code>JIRA_API_TOKEN</code>	An API token for that account	Self-generated at <code>id.atlassian.com/manage-profile/security/api-tokens</code> → Create API token (no admin approval needed, if the account already exists)
<code>JIRA_PROJECT_KEY</code>	The short prefix on ticket numbers in the target project	Visible on any existing issue, e.g. "CC" in "CC-123"

Who actually needs to be involved

This may not require IT at all.

- If **someone on the contact-center team already has a Jira login** with permission to create issues in the target project, they can generate their own API token (the step above is self-service) and hand over those four values directly — no admin ticket required.
- IT (or whoever administers the Jira instance) is only needed if **no one has Jira access yet**, or the destination project doesn't exist — that part does require someone with Jira admin rights to create the project and/or grant access.

Worth asking the contact-center team directly first, since they're the ones who'd already have a working login for their own queue.

Before it goes live with real customer data

- `GET /admin/jira-preview` (the page that renders ticket previews) has **no authentication yet** — gate it before real tickets flow through, per `README.md` 's launch checklist.

- Set the four variables above the same way as `ALLOWED_ORIGINS` — via the Render dashboard's Environment tab if the backend is hosted there.